

Week 7 Synthesis: Learning Theory as Political Choice

Illeris • Ertmer & Newby • Allen • Greeno et al. • Rose • ADDIE Model

The Pattern Across Sources

Each generation of theory claims to overcome prior reductionism while introducing new control: behaviorism → cognitivism → constructivism → situativity. Yet all maintain education's project of making learning predictable and manageable. Reform within systems, not transformation.

Key Questions

- Who defines what counts as legitimate knowledge?
- Can theories designed for compliance serve liberation?
- Why does "average" persist despite evidence of failure?
- Which communities' practices get valued in learning?
- What if "resistance" is rational refusal of domestication?

Critical Insights

ADDIE's evolution: Appropriates theories instrumentally without interrogating purposes

Rose's critique: Challenges standardization but risks reinforcing meritocracy

Illeris's dimensions: Refuses cognition/emotion split, yet maintains Western dominance

Situative potential: Foregrounds participation—but in whose practices?

Learning theory cannot be neutral. The task is making political commitments explicit: Learning for what? Defined by whom? In whose interest? Education either domesticates or liberates.

Theory provides vocabulary, but liberation requires asking different questions